Crusade had no clear leader; the Danes who had joined the German forces soon split off to make their own raids; the Germans themselves disagreed on strategy. In a matter of months, the entire attack had fizzled out. Nothing had been gained except a small amount of loot. Not a single Wend had been baptized.[2]

As a holy war, the Wendish Crusade was a failure.

As a political maneuver, it was more successful. One of the bands of German Crusaders was headed by the eighteen-year-old Henry the Lion, who had a grudge against the king of Germany. Henry's father, Duke of Bavaria and Saxony, had opposed the election of Conrad III (at present still crusading in the east), and Conrad III had punished him by seizing the family lands as soon as the German crown was on his head. After the deposed Duke had died, Conrad III gave Saxony back to young Henry the Lion; but he did not return Bavaria, and Henry the Lion wanted it back.

In the middle of the Wendish Crusade, Henry the Lion managed to make a treaty with the most powerful of the Wendish leaders. Bolstered by this new alliance, he immediately reclaimed the dukedom of Bavaria. He was building his power, wooing allies, reinforcing his army. By 1152, he had become one of the most powerful noblemen in Germany.

In that year, Conrad III of Germany died. Led by Henry the Lion, the German electors gave the crown of Germany not to Conrad's six-year-old son but to one of Henry's own cousins, the thirty-year-old Frederick of Swabia.

Frederick was, in Otto of Freising's words, a "lover of warfare . . . conspicuous for the extension of his kingdom and conquest of peoples." He was also an adept politician; he rewarded his cousin Henry for his support by officially restoring the title Duke of Bavaria. Scrupulous in his religious observances, an enthusiastic hunter, a moderate drinker, sporting an auburn beard (earning him the nickname of "Barbarossa," or "Red-Beard"), Frederick would rule Germany for nearly fifty years; and he would struggle with Henry the Lion for at least half of that time.[3]

He began his reign with a letter to Pope Eugenius III, announcing his election and spelling out exactly how authority in his kingdom was going to be divided. "There are two things by which this world is chiefly ruled," he wrote, quoting the well-known words of the fifth-century pope Gelasius I, "that is, the sacred authority of the pontiffs and the royal power." In other words, the empire had been given to him by God, not by the pope. He was perfectly happy to cooperate with, and even protect, the Church; but he intended to control his own affairs within his own domain. "By our careful application," he concluded, "the catholic church should be adorned by the privileges of its diginity, and the majesty of the Roman Empire should be